BUSINESS & ECONOMY | Start-ups

LIGHTSPEED LEARNINGS: Dreaming big in India. A power couple on love, start-ups, and a rollercoaster ride of success and mistakes

BYJU RAVEENDRAN AND DIVYA GOKULNATH *Co-founders, Byju's*

HARD LESSONS

In the past few years, Byju's has become synonymous with India's rise in the education technology sector. The EdTech multinational's success meant India making leaps; when it ran into rough weather, its peers got cold feet too. With a series of acquisitions, Byju's became the world's largest company in the sector during the Covid-19 pandemic—a cause for much celebration in India. But as the world opened up, the unpleasant news of the firm sacking its employees, alleged "toxic" work culture and "working capital crisis" put a big blot on this growth story.

At the India Today Conclave, founders Byju Raveendran and Divya Gokulnath shared the stories of building the empire, courting controversies and their determination to overcome all "busts". "We are pioneers in EdTech. We are not pioneers in perfection. What we were building was something that was being built in India for the first time in education. We were painting an empty canvas," said Gokulnath, who co-founded the online education platform company with her husband in 2011. Candid enough to accept that mistakes were made on the way, she added, "Sure, we went over the line, but then it's important that we corrected ourselves, we learned along the way and we grew."

On their criticism for having signed big-ticket sports sponsorships at a time when the company was battling for funds, Raveendran reasoned the deals were in the works for months, and aimed to create a "global champion from India" besides brand awareness for the company. "So, when we did the [FIFA World Cup 2022 sponsorship deal], we had about 25 per cent of our students coming [from] outside India," he explained.

Despite the hardships, the couple remained optimistic about both their and India's growth journey. "So you know the wars will not last forever, the interest rates will not rise forever," said Gokulnath. "But the Indian growth story is here to stay." ■

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- The Indian EdTech market is growing at 40 per cent, while the global EdTech market is growing at just 16.5 per cent. India is bound to become the EdTech capital of the world
- Byju founded the EdTech company with his six students about 11 years back. The fact that all of them are still there is a validation that they have not changed their mission of making an impact on students
- The sponsorship deals with FIFA (for the World Cup in Qatar) and the Indian cricket team were designed to create a "global champion from India" and create awareness about the brand globally
- After signing up popular footballer Lionel Messi as the brand ambassador of their social impact arm, Education for All, they have doubled the engagement with NGOs
- Over the last two years, the EdTech giant has impacted 5.5 million children from the deepest parts of the country, half of whom are girls

Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH